

>Look Mom, no command lines!

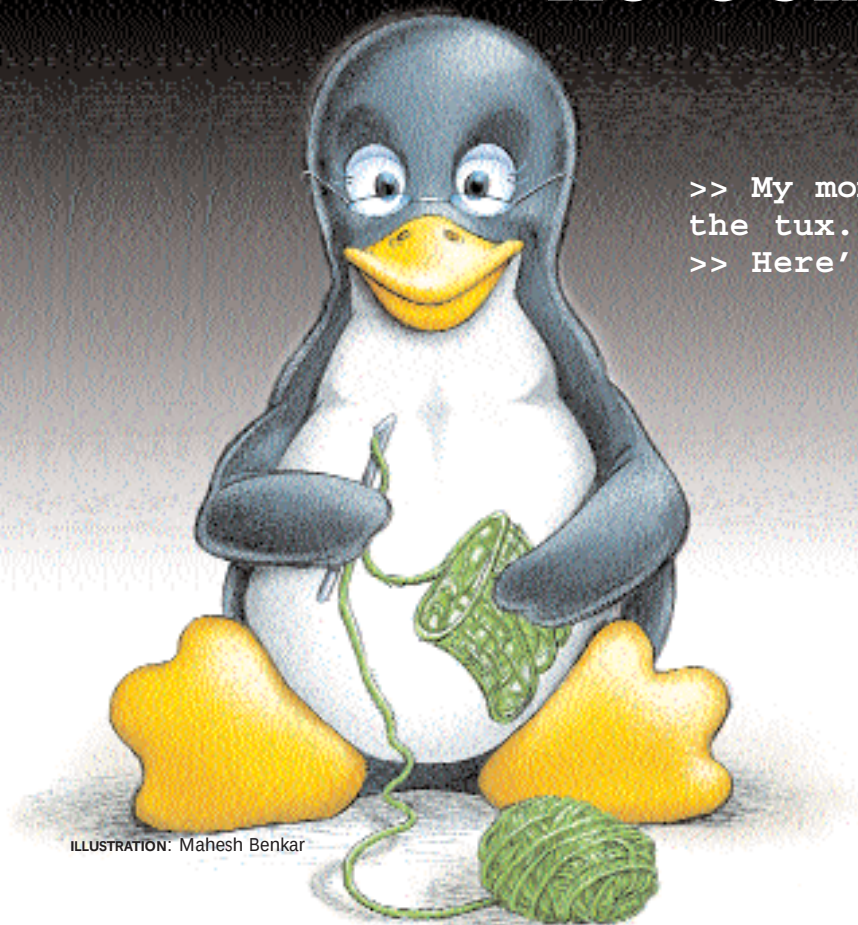


ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

>> My mom is finally smitten by the tux.
>> Here's how it happened...

My mom never liked uncertainty. Just like I hated crashing operating systems, she hated uncertainty. I knew I had to make her life smoother and get her hooked to the non-crashing, reliable Tux who comes with no frills, is extremely cheap, and stays fit thanks to its developer friends the world over. Later, she told me that what she loved best was the freedom to not 'restart the relationship' anymore!

How it all began

The first thing I had to do was shift my mom's focus from the utilitarian, grey Windows world to the spunkier, friendlier realm of the Penguinista. Appearances make all the difference. To get her to work

with Linux, I had to create the perfect environment. Knowing the Tux' strong preferences and pickiness about the hardware that it ran on, I first ensured that my install would not be rudely surprised. A quick check of mom's machine was reassuring. Everything she had—from the ubiquitous i815 motherboard to the standard issue Samsung monitor—were all well supported. I had a choice between KDE and Gnome. I chose KDE since it's the easier interface to use and would appeal more to my mother's aesthetic eye. When installing Linux, I installed both KDE and Gnome. This would later help my mom use applications of both shells and also give her the flexibility to shift between GUIs.

My mother is fussy, she needs a

separate user account (which can be set up while installing), and I appeased this need of hers by going to **Start Application > System User Manager** in KDE (you can do it from the shell also) and creating a home directory where she could store all her files. I also knew that she would get uneasy if things weren't close at hand and organised; it made sense to put shortcuts to all the applications she used on the desktop.

Connecting to the world

While deciding the right browser for Tux, I had a choice between Netscape Navigator, Mozilla and Konqueror. I could have thrown in Opera as well except that it meant another 5 MB download—an hour's waiting time—so I skipped that one. Amongst these, I found Netscape

